

Town of Westhampton  
Town Hall  
1 South Road  
Westhampton, MA 01027

Finance Committee Meeting Minutes  
Tuesday, March 24, 2015

The meeting convened at 6:55 PM

Present:

Finance Committee Members: Jackie Brodeur, Mary Cleary, Tom Cleary, Jr., Maryanne Duggan, Aniko Giordano, Margaret Parsons, Joseph Pipczynski, Ed Zawacki.

Also present: Phil Dowling, Cheryl Provost, Art Pichette, David White, Joe Boudreau.

1. Accepted minutes of 3/17/15. 8-0-0
2. Correspondence: Received letter of Town Meeting articles from the Selectboard. We read through them and noted that they will need to be voted on and returned to the Selectboard by April 16. We will vote on them at our April 7 meeting.
3. Joe Boudreau, Westhampton Town Accountant introduced himself to FinCom and we discussed the Town Accountant budget. Discussed the need for yearly audits to maintain our bond rating and to keep us in good standing for borrowing. We discussed the pros and cons of investing in annual audits versus audits of less frequency. Margie and Joe think it would be a good idea for Anne Marie (Town Treasurer) to discuss this with Clark (the Town's financial advisor).
4. David White, Police Chief, presented the police department budget and the report of the police department. David noted that the Trittech/tech support line of \$2,400 includes \$1,435 of fixed cost for the record management system and the additional funds are for tech support for their department. He is hopeful that if the IT article passes, then the tech support they need can be provided through the town's IT tech support hours allotment as long as that provider is CORI checked. In this case, he would be able to return the balance of the \$2,400 (\$2,400-\$1,435) to the town.

The police department recently received a grant that provided them with mobile and portable radios to help with the communication and back-up systems for the department.

The town did not purchase the speed board that was discussed last year.

David is hopeful that we may be able to have Hampshire Regional contribute to the increase burden on the town to service the regional high school at some point in the

coming years. There is a new unfunded mandate from the state for local towns to dedicate a police officer to the schools.

When discussing revenue sources for the town through the police department, David explained that in general the town officers take an educational approach to traffic stops rather than a punitive approach. The town receives approximately \$25 out of each \$100 pistol permit issued, but that is not a huge revenue source.

The police department is looking to replace the 2008 Crown Victoria in FY17. It would be replaced with a Ford Explorer SUV with a cost of approximately \$43,000. The current vehicle has approximately 60,000 miles on it and they put an additional 20,000 miles on it per year. Given the schedule for preparing a police vehicle once the purchase is approved, they estimate that there will be 80-90,000 miles on it by the time it is replaced.

5. Pat Miller of Council on Aging presented the COA budget. She noted that there is a requested increase in the salary as she would like to budget 25 hours per month rather than 17 since that job actually takes much more time than is currently budgeted. She is also hoping to find a replacement for the COA coordinator position and in order to do that we need to raise the hours/salary. In addition, Highland Valley has previously offset the town's portion of the salary by \$500 and that money is no longer available.

The transportation line of \$500 is to provide a fund within the COA budget to be able to pay the Franklin Regional Transportation in case of overage charges. The charges usually go through the town and are not reflected in this budget.

The funding from Highland Valley is decreasing and the costs for level-funding of the COA are reflected in this budget.

There are over 400 seniors living in Westhampton (approximately a quarter of the population) and they pay almost 30% of the taxes. They are a growing population that is in need of services.

6. Phil Dowling updated us on recent decisions by the Selectboard.

The Selectboard voted to increase the Town Accountant's salary to match those of the Town Treasurer and Tax Collector.

The Selectboard voted to enter into a 3-year contract with the Highway Department to increase their wages by \$0.60 per hour each year over three years.

The Selectboard heard presentations from website designers to create an all-inclusive town site. They have a proposal from Virtual Town Hall to create a site for \$4,200 (which can be spread over three years at no interest). It would cost the town \$1,400 this year and they are hoping to recoup that through the savings of fees for each of the

individual town department websites. The Northampton City website is a model we can look at.

The Building Inspector had requested a salary increase of \$2,600. The Selectboard voted to approve a \$1,300 increase with the expectation that the increase in the fees will cover the additional cost.

7. Next week will we meet with the Library and the Town Clerk. The meeting will start at 7:00pm. We will meet with the Fire Department on 4/7 and also review and vote on the articles at that meeting.

Adjourned at 8:25.

Respectfully Submitted by Mary Cleary